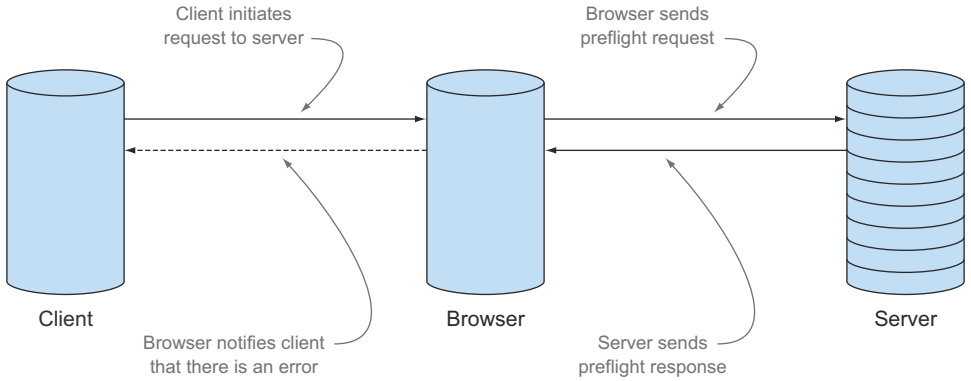


Figure 4.17 If the server rejects a preflight request, the browser returns an error to the client without ever sending the actual request.

Rejecting a CORS request "short-circuits" the request, as shown in figure 4.17. The browser makes the preflight request to the server, and when the server rejects the request, the browser notifies the client code that the request was rejected. The client code doesn't receive the actual preflight response, nor does it receive any additional data about why the request failed (even though the console log shows this information).

As mentioned in chapter 1, servers must opt-in to CORS. That means if a server's response doesn't exactly match what the browser expects, the browser plays it safe and rejects the request. With that in mind, there are many ways for a server to reject a preflight request, including:

- Leave out the Access-Control-Allow-Origin header (if the requested method is not a simple method).
- Return a value in Access-Control-Allow-Methods that doesn't match the Access-Control-Request-Method header.
- If the preflight request has an Access-Control-Request-Headers header:
  - Leave out the Access-Control-Allow-Headers header.
  - Return a value in the Access-Control-Allow-Headers header that doesn't match the Access-Control-Request-Headers header.

Returning a non-200 HTTP response code as the preflight response will not reject the request in some browsers. This may sound surprising, because a non-200 status code is used to signal that something isn't right. But in this case, even though the CORS spec explicitly states that the preflight response should be in the 200 range, some browsers still allow non-200 responses. It's still a good idea to stick to the HTTP 200 or 204 status code, because it adheres to the spec, which won't change.

Table 4.5 shows ways to reject the preflight request. Suppose someone tries to send a request header named `Shady-Status` to the sample app. You don't want your server to receive this header, so the server code should reject the preflight.